

of a proprietary solution. This will delay the agility of the IT team to alter itself as technology changes,” says Balaranjith.

FOSS advantages galore

Going the open source way comes with a lot of perks. “First and foremost is the drastic reduction in the cost of ownership of IT solutions. Even with a subscription model for support, the cost of ownership of open source solutions is very low compared to the regular proprietary solutions. Flexibility to extend and scale your solution is the second big advantage. Since the source code is available, we can tweak the solution to make it run as per our business requirements, easily. Customisation is very difficult and almost not recommended in proprietary solutions. But we have modified all our open source solutions to work on a single platform—LAMP. This was only possible as the source code was available to us for all the OSS,” adds Balaranjith.

Support and maintenance

And how is the firm dealing with the support issue for the deployed OSS? “Most OSS comes with a subscription model. Right now, we didn’t have a reason to go with subscription as we get most of the answers to our queries through online support forums. But we are evaluating taking a subscription for a couple of OSS as we are scaling the solution exponentially these days,” says Balaranjith.

A robust team

The firm boasts of a strong army of 28 open source developers and architects. “We normally take on people from the campus based on their aptitude and analytical skill sets. We also check their interest in OSS as most of our current development is based on open source platforms. We then put them through an initial self-learning training period on various platforms, in which seniors from the team provide guidance on various solution offerings,” adds Balaranjith.

Balaranjith says it is very important to have a competent IT team that has the motivation and aptitude to go the open source way. “Open source is not about saving money without software licences, but also about flexibility, scalability and the agility of your IT solutions. A robust team of IT professionals that has the passion to learn the finer nuances of FOSS can make a firm excel. Today, almost every new technology introduced has an open source flavour to it. So catch the bus before it is too late,” he signs off.

The case study of Atul Limited bears testament to the fact that FOSS can be a great weapon in the arsenal of any successful firm. 

By Priyanka Sarkar

The author is a member of the editorial team. She loves to weave in and out the little nuances of life and scribble her thoughts and experiences in her personal blog.



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